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Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/36203179.

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Teen And Up Audiences

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# I'll settle for the ghost of you

by TurtleTotem

Summary

When Adora sacrifices herself to close the portal, the Rebellion is devastated by the loss — and so is Catra, though she'd rather die than admit it. Is that why she keeps hearing Adora's voice, seeing her in the corner of her eye? Is she hallucinating, or is some part of Adora really still here to haunt her?

# Chapter 1

Catra had always had trouble sleeping. Once upon a time, curling up on Adora's bed and listening to her slow inhales and exhales—feeling her warmth, breathing her safe, familiar scent—had helped more than anything else. Catra wasn't sure she'd had a single night of deep, unbroken sleep since Adora left.

She certainly hadn't last night, dozing fitfully until the Fright Zone's sullen version of dawn glared in her eyes, prompting her to roll away from the window. Right now, it felt like she would never sleep again. Because even though she'd long since given up hope of Adora coming home, it was different knowing it for a fact. Knowing she would never see Adora again.

Adora was dead.

When the portal reality had collapsed and Catra found herself on the floor of Hordak's sanctum, she'd noticed instantly that Adora was missing. She-Ra's sword had hovered for a moment in the whirling, distorted energy field of the portal, then clattered to the floor—where Princess Glimmer had snatched it up and hacked the portal device apart with it. She-Ra's sword, but no She-Ra. The princesses had called for her, searching frantically, but within moments they all had to flee the crumbling sanctum. Catra had hauled Hordak out as Shadow Weaver and Glimmer teleported the princesses away.

On Catra's orders, the whole Fright Zone had been searched for Adora. But they found nothing, and Catra hadn't known what to make of it, until yesterday—when the somber announcement came from Bright Moon, brought to her attention by every scout and spy the Horde had.

She-Ra had sacrificed herself to close the portal. Queen Angella of Bright Moon had witnessed it, apparently. To save everyone else from dissolving into unreality, Adora had taken that fate on herself alone. Now she was gone forever.

A knock sounded on Catra's chamber door, metal echoing.

"What?" Catra snarled, startling herself with the harshness of her own voice.

Kyle's nervous voice, muffled by the door. "Lord Hordak wants to see you in his sanctum."

*What's left of it.* It was about time Hordak bestirred himself to actually take some kind of action; for days now everyone had been walking on eggshells, waiting to be told what to do. "Fine," she snapped, and listened to Kyle's boots retreating down the corridor.

Only after a long moment and a deep breath did she sit up, rubbing her face—she had grit in her eyes, that was all. That was *all*—and try to prepare herself to see Hordak.

She did not figure he was going to be happy with her.

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If Catra had thought Hordak might spend his three-day sulk fixing up the wrecked sanctum, she was disabused of that notion immediately. She had to pick her way through bent metal and shattered glass toward the console where Hordak waited, slumped and facing away from her.

She'd almost reached him when her foot hit a broken pair of manacles. Adora's manacles, the ones that had held her hands above and behind her while she begged Catra to listen, just *listen*…

The sight of Adora bound and begging had felt… a lot of different ways at the same time. Good, bad, everything in between. And remembering it now felt even stranger, knowing Adora had been right about the portal. And Catra hadn't listened. And now Adora was dead.

The sting of kicking the manacle made Catra's voice come out unwisely belligerent. "Hordak, our troops are just sitting around

here. What are we waiting for? We need to talk about plans for—"

"Plans." Hordak's laughter was dark and unsettling. "Your last plan was to set off the portal machine before it was ready. Do you remember how *that* ended?"

Catra crossed her arms defensively. "Whatever. It worked out for us, didn't it? The Rebellion's a mess. She-Ra is gone. Now's our chance to gain the upper hand."

Hordak stood—somehow she always forgot how *big* he was—and walked toward her. "And how are we going to do that," he said, as Catra gave ground, hating herself for doing it and him for making her, "when you couldn't even keep the Rebellion from infiltrating the Fright Zone?"

"Yeah, like I said before, it was Entrapta—"

Hordak *roared* and began smashing things. A steel beam fell within inches of crushing Catra.

*"I told you never to mention that name in my presence!"* He whirled back toward her—which put his chest almost directly before her eyes. His chest, which bore a pink-purple First Ones chip embedded in the armor.

"If you are so desperate for a task—"

The chip didn't match Hordak's armor. That was Entrapta's color, Entrapta's work.

"—redouble our defenses so that no princess can ever set foot in the Fright Zone again."

Catra tore her eyes away from the chip before Hordak could notice her noticing it.

"Fortunately for you," Hordak said, pointing toward a screen, cracked but still functional, where a symbol was blinking, "my signal to Horde Prime went through. That is the only reason," he

backed her up another step, "you are standing here," another, "instead of facing punishment," and another, all the way to the door, "for your failure. Now, get out!"

He went back to the console and punched a button, closing the door.

Catra stared at the door, not really seeing it, a smile creeping across her face. Her heart was still pounding, adrenaline sizzling through her veins, but Hordak had frightened her for the last time. He was never going to treat her like that again.

Because if Hordak was keeping something Entrapta made, Entrapta whose name he couldn't bear to hear, it was because he *needed* it. Desperately.

*And anything people know you* need *is a weakness.*

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Any information about the chip in Hordak's chest was most likely to be in Entrapta's quarters. Catra hoped she wasn't too late; it was supposed to have been cleared out already, but she doubted anyone had been in a hurry to act on those orders. Entrapta's belongings were too likely to explode without warning.

(What belongings had Adora left behind, in whatever palatial room she had in Bright Moon? Who would keep them, who would remember her? Catra would never know. *Not relevant, not relevant*.)

Sure enough, when Catra came through the door, she saw plenty of chaos and mess remaining in Entrapta's chamber. And the only person inside didn't appear to be cleaning anything up.

"What are you doing here?" Catra said, exasperated.

Scorpia turned toward her with a useless stammer, holding a bowl of bolts, nuts and metal bobs. If that was her idea of clearing the place out, no wonder it was taking so long.

"You heard Hordak," Catra continued.  "He wants all this junk disposed of as soon as possible." Absently, she picked up one of Entrapta's toys, a puppy-like thing that made a wheezing noise when she squeezed it.

Catra remembered Entrapta making that toy, remembered sitting on the worktable while she fine-tuned it, both of them laughing at the noise it made.

Scorpia was talking, she realized belatedly. "—made a heat of the moment decision which I totally get, but, um, you didn't really want Entrapta to stay on Beast Island forever," she said in a tone of nervous confidence, as if *of course* Catra hadn't really *meant it*. "Anyway, I was thinking we could go back and get her? I mean, she is our friend."

*Our friend.* Catra, glaring at Scorpia, clenched the toy until it shattered in her hand. "Entrapta betrayed us," *me, betrayed me*, "and got what she deserved."

"You know that's not true."

Catra spun toward the voice behind her… but there was no one there.

She knew that voice. Knew it down to her bones.

"Glimmer didn't need Entrapta to let her in." *Adora's* voice. A little confused, a little cocky—it was a combination Catra knew well. "And you… you heard me just now, didn't you?"

"Entrapta just wanted to save us from the portal." *That* was Scorpia, sounding bewildered. She was looking past Catra curiously, following her line of sight, but clearly not seeing anything Catra didn't. "And she was right—if Adora hadn't shut it down—"

Rage swept through Catra's body like a firestorm. *"Don't you say her name to me,"* she snarled, and slammed Scorpia against the wall, claws spearing into the metal next to Scorpia's head.

Scorpia stammered some more. "Who? Adora? Why?"

"Augh! Life must be so hard for someone who's *always* so confused!" Catra yanked her claws free, a motion that slashed up the wall even more. She took a breath. "The portal left the Rebellion in shambles, and that means *it worked*. Got it?"

Scorpia nodded, less in agreement than submission. Catra didn't care, why should she care what Scorpia really thought, as long as she did as she was told? It wasn't like they were friends.

"Good," Catra said, trying to breathe evenly, calmly. She smoothed her hair back. *Wild*, that was what Shadow Weaver had always called her hair. *Out of control*. But Catra was perfectly in control.

"Get this place cleared out, Scorpia," Catra said, calm and pleasant and *in control*, and left the room.

"You don't want to hear my name, huh?" said Adora, from somewhere nearby, invisible. "Like Hordak doesn't want to hear Entrapta's? Well, you're gonna hear a lot more than that."

# Chapter 2

Chapter Notes

> Just FYI: I'm mostly not going to bother rehashing scenes that play out the same way they did in canon. In this chapter, for instance, I skip over the actual confrontation with Hordak. That kind of thing will happen more than once in this story.

Catra refused to react to Adora's voice for most of the day. *It's not real*, she told herself, *it's not real, it's not her. She's dead*. That thought wasn't actually any more comforting than the idea that she was losing her mind, but it was the truth.

Adora's voice followed everywhere Catra went, sometimes right beside her, sometimes wandering the room. She asked questions, brought up old memories, leveled accusations—at one point she even started singing, loud and confidently off-key. Anything to get Catra to react, it seemed. But none of it worked.

Eventually, all her duties accomplished, Catra had no further excuse to avoid her own quarters. Especially since she needed somewhere quiet to figure out her next move. Well… somewhere private. *Quiet* was apparently not going to happen.

"—don't know why you can hear me when no one else does, but I'm so glad someone can. I don't know if I'm a ghost or what—"

*Not real*, Catra repeated, and tried to tune it out as she paced her quarters. She needed to focus on Hordak. She knew his weakness now. She could use that. Finally, she had leverage she could use to *make* Hordak listen to her.

"—ignoring me, but I am *going* to make you listen to me, Catra—"

This peculiar echo of her own thoughts startled Catra into answering. "No, I'm not," she snapped. "I'm not going to listen to you. You're a hallucination, brought on by sleep deprivation or just… stress! You're not real and I'm not going to listen to you!"

"Sleep deprivation and stress, huh?" Adora said. "Not guilt? Not even a tiny bit of guilt?"

Catra braced her arms against the little utilitarian sink in the corner of her quarters, fighting a sudden surge of nausea. "I have nothing to feel guilty about. I didn't kill you. You made your own choice."

"What else was I supposed to choose?" Adora said coldly. "Because of the portal *you* opened, everyone on the planet was going to die. Including me, come to that. For me, there was no way out."

"I didn't know any of that was going to happen!" Catra heard the note of desperation in her own voice and snapped her teeth shut. "It doesn't matter," she said, closing her eyes. "I can't deal with *you* right now. I need to focus on confronting Hordak. It's time to stop sitting around, waiting for the scraps of power he deigns to drop on me. I'm going to step up beside him and *take* what I want."

"You were always good at that," Adora said, her voice still icy.

"As if you didn't spend your whole life wanting what I'm getting now," Catra snapped. "We were supposed to do this together. Until you *left*."

Adora's voice gentled—sad, instead of angry. "I wanted us to rule because we were *better* than Hordak, not worse."

"Well, you don't get a vote now. You left me." Her voice cracked. "And this time, you're never coming back."

Silence.

Catra opened her eyes, examined her reflection. Wild, scrappy, tattered—that was how she'd always looked. It was time for a change. Time to look like someone who was in charge, in control. Hadn't Entrapta had some hair tonic that kept her insanely long prehensile locks from getting tangled? Entrapta wouldn't be using

it now, so Catra might as well. (She ruthlessly ignored the part of her that flinched at the thought.) Those gray tufts on either side—those had to go. She hadn't been able to bear the sight of them for weeks, ever since Shadow Weaver… She'd look much neater without them. As for her clothes, the uniform department had been after her to upgrade ever since she made Force Captain. They were about to get what they wanted, with a rush on. She'd get colors that matched her mask instead of clashing with it. And a design that looked more dignified, more serious.

She ran a hand down her right arm and thought about how it had looked, after she clawed her way out of the portal's first attempt to disintegrate her. Smooth, cold, pure black. It had looked *dangerous*. She wanted to look like that again.

*"You made your choice. Now live with it."* This time Adora's voice was only in her memory. The last words she'd said to Catra, as reality collapsed around them. The last *real* words Adora would ever say to her, regardless of whatever hallucination was happening now.

Catra's eyes focused abruptly on a figure reflected behind her in the mirror. Grey-blue eyes met hers for a moment that felt like—like Shadow Weaver's magic, a painful electricity holding her frozen.

"Catra?" Adora whispered, breathless with hope. "Can you see me?"

"No," Catra snarled.

"Hey, uh, Catra!" Scorpia spilled into the room, knocking at the same time that she opened the door. "There's some of this stuff that I really think we should hold onto, I think Hordak's gonna want it once he's, um, feeling better. Can you come take a look?"

Catra let Scorpia sweep her out of the room, refusing to glance in the mirror again.

"I honestly don't know whether to be horrified or impressed, Catra."

Catra flinched before she could stop herself. She had hoped that maybe, just maybe, winning against Hordak had put her hallucinations of Adora to rest. She hadn't seen or heard her for hours. But now it was the dead of night, and Catra was staring into the darkness of her quarters, far too wired to sleep, and Adora was back.

"That thing with Hordak," Adora continued, "that was brutal."

"Fortunately, I don't care about your opinion," Catra said, and rolled over, away from the voice.

"Right," Adora said. "That's why you kept looking for me in mirrors all day."

"I did not." She totally had, every time she passed a reflective surface.

"I never thought you'd grow up to be someone who enjoyed hurting people," Adora said.

Catra scoffed. "I didn't hurt Hordak. I just showed him I *could*. Anyway he's hurt me often enough." She *had* enjoyed scaring him, holding power over him. Wouldn't anyone?

"You enjoy hurting me," Adora said, her voice not accusatory, just… sad.

Catra growled impatiently, forcing the sound past the lump in her throat. "You were never *really* hurt. You're She-Ra, you heal right up like it's nothing." Except this last time. There was no healing from what had happened to her now. Catra bit her lip hard.

"You think I don't feel pain when I'm She-Ra? I do. It even leaves scars sometimes. I can show you." A rustle of clothing. "Come on, turn over and look in the mirror. *Look* at me, Catra."

Electricity again, raising all the hair on Catra's skin. She bit her lip again, hard enough to taste blood, and did not turn around.

A long moment, and then Adora sighed, clothes rustling again as if she were putting them back in place. "You were different in the… the portal world, the weird fake reality it built. 'Everything is perfect,' that's what people kept saying. What *you* kept saying. And in this world you thought was perfect, you weren't sitting on Hordak's throne. You weren't even a Force Captain." Her voice went wistful, almost pleading. "Things were back the way they used to be. Me and you together."

"Not completely the way it used to be," Catra said hoarsely.

"Yeah, you're right." Adora sounded thoughtful. "Some things were different. People treated you differently."

*Shadow Weaver was proud of me. The other cadets liked me. I was part of the team, part of… a family, almost.* Hot humiliation drove Catra to finally sit up, snarling. "I wasn't the only one building that perfect world, Adora. And you weren't a princess in it. You were back home with me. So what does *that* say?"

Adora didn't answer, and Catra was almost too distracted to notice. Because she could *see* Adora. Not in the mirror, but right in front of her, standing beside the bed with a scowl on her face and her hands on her hips. She looked solid and real and alive, except that her legs and feet faded downward into transparency.

The temptation to reach out and touch, to feel Adora's hand or hair or cheek one last time, was so intense Catra couldn't breathe. So intense that she didn't dare actually try to touch. She didn't know how she would survive it if her hand went right through, the way it surely would, because Adora wasn't really here. She wasn't anywhere, anymore.

Adora's scowl faded as they looked at each other. "You can see me," she whispered. "Right? You're looking right at me."

Catra didn't reply, still staring.

Adora reached toward her.

Catra snatched herself away, turning over in the bed. "Go away, Adora," she managed in a choked whisper. "I'm tired. I want to sleep."

"I'm tired, too," Adora said softly. "I don't think I sleep anymore, exactly. It's been days, and I'm so tired... But I can stop trying to be visible, at least." Her voice suddenly became fainter, almost muffled. "I'll be back, though. I'll be here when you wake up."

"I wish that were true," Catra whispered before she could stop herself, but if Adora heard, she gave no sign.

Catra had always had trouble sleeping alone. She slept better that night than she had since Adora left.

# Chapter 3

"Where do you go, when you're not here?"

It took Adora a moment to realize Catra was talking to her. She wasn't looking toward Adora at all, and they were outside—high on a roof, overseeing the loading of experimental weaponry onto a transport. No one else was in earshot, true, but Catra rarely talked to her unless they were *completely* alone. Talking to people no one else could see wasn't good for anyone's reputation, but a Horde leader least of all. And so far, no one else had been able to see Adora, no matter how hard she tried to make them.

"I don't go anywhere," Adora said.

"You're not always here, though. You fade away, sometimes for hours, and you don't answer when I…" Catra cleared her throat. "You don't hear or see the things that happen when you're gone."

Was Catra calling for her, when she wasn't around? The thought made Adora's chest ache in a way she couldn't articulate.

"A few days ago, you said you don't sleep," Catra continued. "So what are you doing? Where do you go, when you're not with me?"

"Sometimes I walk around," Adora shrugged. "Looking at the places I remember… It's weird being back here." And weird walking unseen, passing through walls and doors without effort, trying not to think too hard about why she wasn't sinking through the floor. "And no, I don't sleep, but… when I let go of trying to be here… I guess it is a bit like falling asleep, but instead of darkness, it's light. Everything goes out of focus and just becomes light, clouds of it, bright and silent. It's hard to come back from, sometimes. Hard to… remember myself, pull myself back together."

Catra looked at her then, finally, her expression unreadable. "Don't—don't do that, then. Don't let go like that."

"I can't help it." Adora raised an eyebrow. "Anyway, I thought I was just a hallucination that you wanted to get rid of."

"Force Captain Catra." An approaching soldier stopped and saluted. "I have those reports you requested from the Crimson Waste, and Squad 8 is preparing to depart with you in the morning."

"Good." Catra took a folder from the soldier's hand. "Thank you."

"Depart? To the Crimson Waste?" Adora said as the soldier walked off.

Catra nodded, glancing at the departing soldier's back. "Mara's ship," she murmured under her breath.

Adora snorted. "If the Rebellion hasn't beaten you to it."

"The Rebellion's been pretty distracted," Catra said absently, scanning the contents of the folder. "We've had a strong presence in the Waste for weeks now with no pushback. I guess the princesses don't care about protecting thieves and smugglers from the big, bad Horde."

"We didn't even know anyone lived there until we went looking for the ship! And don't pretend you did, either." Adora craned her neck, trying to see what Catra was reading. "I don't know if I can come with you or not. Won't know until I try, I guess."

Catra crooked a brow. "Do you want to?"

"Of course."

"You're in that big a hurry to see sand and cacti again?"

"I'm in a hurry to see what you find on Mara's ship. I want to hear the rest of her message." *And I want to stay with you*. "What, you don't want me to come?"

"Why would I? Like you said, you're just a hallucination I want to be rid of." Catra glanced up from the folder, and Adora was surprised to realize how close together their faces were. "I guess if you're all in my head, you'll go wherever I go. If you're a ghost, though," Catra looked away again, "you probably won't be able to leave the place where you died."

Adora cocked her head. "This isn't where I died."

"What do you mean?"

"I didn't die in the Fright Zone. To close the portal, I had to go back to—well, I don't know where it is, exactly. But it's this place, like a meadow, where I came through a portal as a baby."

"What?" Catra looked baffled.

"I guess you wouldn't know," Adora said. "Turns out I wasn't born on Etheria. I came through a portal from… I don't know, somewhere else. Wherever the First Ones went when they left here. I'm… I'm a First One. That's why I'm able to wield the Sword."

Catra stared at her. "Okay," she said eventually. "That's a really weird thing for my own brain to come up with, so, one point toward you not being a hallucination. But still, none of what happened in the portal world was *real*. When it closed, everyone was back here where they started. Except you, but your sword was here… Or were you there after all? Like—like this. Like you are now."

Adora grimaced. "Not really. Everything was blurry light at first, like I told you about. Took me a while to come out of that. I got out by following your voice, actually." Adora hadn't known she was going to say that until the words came out. She tried to will the heat out of her cheeks.

"My voice?" Catra repeated. "What do you mean? What was I saying?"

Adora shrugged. "My name," she said, trying to sound very, very casual. "I think. I don't know, it was, um, it was hard to hear."

What she'd heard was Catra sobbing desperately, curled in a painfully tight ball on the floor, surrounded by the shredded remains of what seemed to be reports. Reports, Adora saw on closer inspection, about the death of She-Ra. Catra had said Adora's name, yes, more than once, though Adora wasn't sure she knew she was doing it.

She'd tried to talk to Catra then, tried to touch her. Couldn't pull herself into sharp enough focus for it, and the effort had exhausted her, sent her back into the bright blur for a while. It took a couple more attempts before she'd been able to make Catra hear her voice. By then, Catra wasn't showing any signs of grief at all.

"Well," Catra said now, her voice sharp, her cheeks possibly a little red, "I guess we'll find out if you can *follow my voice* all the way to the Crimson Waste. We leave at dawn. And I have orders to give about it." She walked off briskly, and Adora didn't follow.

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Whether she was a ghost or hallucination or what, accompanying Catra to the Crimson Waste turned out to be as easy as walking onto the transport with her. That was the only easy part of any of it.

"Are you really going to trust that shapeshifter?" Adora demanded when everything was over, and Catra was alone in her tent, camped halfway back to the Fright Zone.

"You saw what Double Trouble can do," Catra said gleefully. She turned away from the tent flap where Scorpia and Double Trouble had just departed, and started undressing for bed.

Adora did *not* choke, averting her gaze from Catra's body as she pulled off her uniform. The new uniform that made her look so different, sleek and poised and mature. Underneath it she still

looked mostly the same, but—it felt strange to look, now, in a way that it never had before.

"Yeah, I saw what they can do," Adora said. "And they're willing to sell those services to the highest bidder."

"Which, fortunately, I am."

"Until the day you aren't."

Catra snorted, pulling her gray sleep-gear into place. "Like your perfect princess friends would ever stoop to hiring a mercenary."

"I don't know, Glimmer can be pretty… pragmatic."

"Yeah, she was in a mood, wasn't she?"

"A *mood*?" It had torn Adora apart to see her friends show up to fight for Mara's ship—Glimmer and Bow, accompanied by Perfuma and Huntara—all of them the worse for wear. Glimmer looked like she hadn't been sleeping, and though *in a mood* was a flippant way to put it, she'd certainly been hotheaded and violent even for Glimmer. The sight of Catra had sent her into a frenzy of rage that nearly got her killed.

"It's clear they're not doing too well without their precious She-Ra," Catra said, more to herself than Adora.

"Well enough to get Mara's ship away from you," Adora said coldly. "It's pretty rich of you to stand here and make fun of my friends for being upset that I'm dead."

"If they miss you so much, why couldn't any of them see you?" Catra snapped, hackles raised and tail lashing.

"If I'm a ghost, maybe I'm just here to haunt the one who killed me," Adora said, not letting Catra see that she'd hit a nerve. She'd shouted and cried, standing in front of Glimmer and Bow, her outstretched hands going right through them, and they never gave the slightest sign of perceiving her.

Catra was glaring at her, one lip lifted away from her fangs. "If this is your idea of haunting me, you're pretty bad at it. So far you've barely managed to be annoying." Her hair whipped as she turned away to unfold her bedroll.

"I'll have to work on that," Adora said dryly. "Anyway, you didn't answer me about the shapeshifter. They're not even *that* good, you know. Sure, they fooled Glimmer and Bow—people who don't know you that well. They never would have fooled me."

Catra barked a laugh. "They *did* fool you, and you know it. I saw your face, trying to figure out which of us was real."

Adora crossed her arms, scowling. "That was different! I didn't even know there *was* a shapeshifter, of course I was confused!"

"And the Rebellion doesn't know there's a shapeshifter, either. They won't suspect a thing." Catra crawled into her bedroll, and flopped onto her back, arms over her head, to grin at the roof of the tent. "Double Trouble might just win this whole stupid war for me, and all they want in return is money! If I still believed in friends, they'd be my best one."

"I don't understand you, Catra. You don't need to *buy* a best friend. Even if I'm not in the running anymore—"

*"If?"*

"—Force Captain Scorpia would walk through fire for you! Anyone can see that. Why would you rather have someone whose loyalty is a hundred percent bought?" Adora sighed. "Oh. That's the *point*, isn't it. It's like you said, all Double Trouble wants from you is money. What Scorpia wants is a lot scarier."

Catra sneered. "You think I'm scared of *Scorpia*?"

"I think you're scared of yourself," Adora said. "You're scared to care about anyone. Maybe that's my fault."

"Don't flatter yourself," Catra snapped. "I've told you before, you leaving was the best thing that ever happened to me. I could finally get out of your shadow and prove myself without your interference. And look where I am now!"

"Yeah," Adora said softly. "Just look."

Catra frowned, eyes scanning the room. "Adora?"

She was fading out, Adora realized. She was tired, her whole soul hurt, and the world was losing focus, all the lights and shadows running together.

"Adora!" Catra called again, impatient and annoyed and maybe just the tiniest bit pleading, but Adora let go, and didn't answer.

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"Adora!"

The sound of Catra calling her pulled Adora back into focus, more quickly than she could usually manage on her own. The tent was dark—no, wait. This wasn't the tent. They were in Catra's quarters, back at the Fright Zone. Adora felt a chill up her spine, wondering how long she had been gone. And, for that matter, how she'd managed to get here, instead of being left behind halfway out of the desert.

"Adora!" Catra cried again, thrashing in the bed with her claws extended and her teeth set in a snarl. *Fighting*, Adora thought. *Fighting* me*, even in her sleep*. She didn't want to watch that. It was tempting to let herself fade out again—but what if she couldn't pull herself back again?

"I don't know," Catra said, in answer to some dream-question Adora couldn't hear. "I don't *know*—please—don't, please!"

Catra wasn't angry, Adora realized abruptly. She was scared.

"Entrapta," Catra gasped, voice indistinct with sleep. "Oh, what did I do? Entrapta… *Get her out of here!"*

Adora had been walking unseen around Catra and Scorpia long enough to figure out what had happened to Entrapta. If Catra was having guilt-nightmares about it, Adora was *glad*. She deserved to. Frankly it was the best sign she'd seen that there was hope for Catra to change.

But if that was what she was dreaming, it wasn't the only thing. Adora watched as she began clawing at the bed, as if to keep herself from being dragged away. If she'd been scared before, she was *terrified* now, nearly sobbing with it.

"Help," Catra cried, muffled into her pillow, hardly able to breathe. "Help me! Please, Adora!"

Adora gasped as if she'd been burned. Maybe Catra did deserve this nightmare—but Adora couldn't watch her suffer like this, and not try to help her. Maybe not anyone, but certainly not Catra.

On instinct, Adora tried to shake her—but of course her hand went through Catra's shoulder. "Wake up," she shouted instead. "Catra, *wake up!"*

No response. Catra strangled a scream into her pillow.

"Catra!" Adora crouched next to the bed, put her face inches from Catra's, and tried something she hadn't done since they were tiny. Back before they even had separate beds, back before Shadow Weaver got tetchy about them cuddling and hugging. She began to sing.

She had no idea where the lullaby came from; it was passed around among the younger cadets from year to year, along with sillier and ruder songs. Everyone knew instinctively not to get caught singing any of them, but on stormy nights someone always started it up. Adora didn't know if she'd remember all the words, but once she started, it all came back with no effort at all.

*Goodnight, goodnight, the dark will not hurt you*
*Goodnight, sleep tight, sweet dreams*

*Goodnight, goodnight, I'm here, I'll protect you*
*Goodnight, sleep tight, sweet dreams*

*Goodnight, goodnight, we're safe from the weather*
*Goodnight, sleep tight, sweet dreams*
*Goodnight, goodnight, we're safe here together*
*Goodnight, sleep tight, sweet dreams*

Catra gradually quieted as Adora sang, the tension and terror draining out of her. She turned her face toward Adora's voice, tears still trailing down her cheeks—but they looked like relief now, instead of fear.

Adora stayed on the floor next to the bed for the rest of the night, singing another verse of the lullaby any time Catra so much as shifted in her sleep, and told herself it was just because she had nothing better to do.

# Chapter 4

Adora stared, horrified, down into the pit full of prisoners from Elberon.

"Your friends are so predictable," Catra said next to her. "The new bot drew Arrow Boy and Princess Sparkles away from the village like a charm. And with the regenerating tech, there were *four* bots by the time they figured out how to destroy them without triggering the creation of new ones. We had plenty of time to scoop these people up like fish in a net. Fish in a barrel, now." She gestured down at the huddled groups of moth-folk villagers in the pit.

"What are you going to do with them?" Adora asked, dread heavy in her stomach.

"Nothing," Catra shrugged. "They're just bait for the *bigger* fish. Your friends will show up to rescue them any minute now." She glanced at Adora, and rolled her eyes. "You can stop looking like that. This whole plan is about getting Double Trouble into position, not flattening your unsuspecting friends. Tempting as that may be."

"Do you promise?" Adora said. "You promise you're not going to hurt them?" Not that inserting a spy into their midst wasn't bad enough…

Catra's expression hardened. "Suddenly you believe in promises again? I'm not making you any *promises*, Adora."

Scorpia came down the gangway toward them with her usual wide, earnest smile. "Look at us," she said expansively, "you and me in the field, side by side! Taking a bunch of random prisoners from a party, putting said prisoners in a big pit, guarding said pit—ah, if that doesn't say friendship, I don't know what does. The super pal duo is *back!*"

It hurt to watch, really. At least Scorpia didn't know Adora was here, watching her trying so desperately to be Catra's friend.

Catra, meanwhile, turned her attention pointedly to her tracker pad. "What about the weapons we confiscated?" she asked flatly.

"Oh! Oh yeah, you gotta see this!" Scorpia darted off around a corner—and the cannon on the tank they'd seized in Elberon fired, filling the air with confetti. Catra yelped, throwing her tracker pad into the air, and Adora laughed heartily—despite having jumped halfway out of her skin herself.

"Huh? Huh?" Scorpia called delightedly, returning from around the corner. "I know it's just cut up pieces of paper but gosh, isn't it so much fun?"

"Shut *up*, Adora," Catra hissed, one ear twitching, as Adora continued to snicker.

"What?" Scorpia said.

"I said, we need to focus." Catra turned and walked down the gangway, Scorpia trailing after. "Princess Glimmer was in Elberon, which means she's nearby."

"Do you think she'll try some secret attack?"

"Oh, I'm counting on it."

"You didn't even tell Scorpia what you're doing?" Adora said. "How is she supposed to help you if you don't tell her anything?"

"I don't *need* Sc—your help, Scorpia!" Catra snapped, cutting off Scorpia's babble, which had amounted to the same thing Adora said.

"Sure, sure, I know," Scorpia said tentatively. "Still, it's always nice to have an extra pairs of hands—or pincers—and you know I love being useful! I'm sure this isn't something you're doing on purpose but I've felt a little left out since the whole portal thing—"

"Get over it," Catra snarled, and Scorpia fell into crestfallen silence.

An alert sounded on Catra's tracker pad. "Aha," she said, mouth curling upward. "The Rebels are here."

Adora drew a shaky breath. "I'm going to warn them. You can't stop me."

"I don't need to," Catra muttered smugly, earning a curious glance from Scorpia. Adora dashed away without replying.

It burned that Catra was probably right. In the Crimson Waste, she hadn't been able to get her friends to see or hear her at all. But she had to try. She couldn't just watch them walk into a trap without *trying* to warn them.

She jogged to the main entrance first, but there were no signs of disturbance there. Of course, they would have tried a more discreet back entrance. Ugh, which one? The closest was the loading bay—

And suddenly she was there. Adora rocked back on her heels, bewildered by the change in surroundings. How had she gotten here? Everywhere else she'd gone, she'd had to walk or ride a transport, and while she didn't exactly get tired (not from walking, anyway), it still took time. But this was the first time she'd really *wanted* to be somewhere particular, and in a hurry. This was how it had worked in the portal reality, wasn't it? She thought about going somewhere and there she was.

Anyway, the loading bay looked calm and normal, a handful of soldiers desultorily unloading a transport of supplies. They weren't here. Adora focused her mind on going to the personnel door on the east side—

And there she was, or at what remained of it. It had been busted open, and was surrounded by a ring of unconscious guards, some starting to groan and sit up. Adora grinned; yep, this was the right place.

Shouts and the sounds of magic and laser fire drew her further into the building, and before long she found them.

For a moment she felt frozen, chest overflowing with bittersweet emotion. There was Glimmer, shouting triumphantly as she teleported back and forth, punching Horde soldiers and ripping weapons out of their hands. Bow fired a net-arrow, neutralizing a soldier who had nearly gotten the drop on Glimmer with a stun baton. Swift Wind—*Swift Wind!* she hadn't expected him—was kicking in a door. And with him was—

Flutterina. That was the name Catra and Double Trouble had given the… character they'd invented, the girl from Elberon, all pink ribbons and starry-eyed flattery. Even knowing full well who she—or they—really were, Adora found it hard to believe, when she was watching the moth-girl flinch from laser fire, then set her jaw with adorable determination and rush a soldier from the side, tackling him away from his tripod gun.

Glimmer was moving around too much to approach. Adora ran to Bow, who was firing from behind cover now.

"Bow! Bow, listen to me. *Don't trust Flutterina*. She's a Horde spy. Bow, please give some sign you can hear me!"

Bow moved right through her to fire an arrow, giving no indication he perceived her at all.

Adora pulled in a deep breath, trying to focus, concentrate. If only she could call on the power of She-Ra… but she didn't have the sword. Somehow that had stayed behind in reality, even though it had been in her hand when she went through the portal.

But Catra could see her, if she just focused a little, so clearly it was possible. Adora just had to try harder.

*"Don't trust Flutterina,"* she said again, trying to project the words directly into Bow's mind with pure strength of will.

"This way!" Swift Wind called from across the room, and the others ran after him.

Swift Wind. She-Ra's magic steed. *Sacred bond*. Adora's heart lurched with sudden hope, and she found herself beside him as quickly as she'd traveled from one entrance to the other.

"Ha! You are no match for—ow!" Swift Wind cried, a laser blast singeing his tail as he dropped on an unsuspecting tripod gun and kicked it apart, its gunner fleeing.

"Swift Wind! Come on, Swift Wind. I know you can hear me, I know it. Come on, Swiftie!"

Swift Wind stopped dead, his eyes scanning the room in apparent confusion. "Hey, uh, Flutterina, did you hear something?"

Flutterina blinked sparkling fuschia eyes. "No…?"

"You heard me." Heart racing, Adora let her hands hover on either side of his muzzle. *Sacred bond, sacred bond*. "You heard me. Swift Wind, I'm here. I need to warn you about Flutterina. She's not what she seems. You can't trust her. Oh, please say you hear me."

"Swift Wind! You okay?" Bow asked as he ran past.

"The villagers should be in a pit, right over here!" Glimmer shouted, gesturing wildly.

"Yeah, yeah, I'm fine! Right behind you!" Swift Wind ran through Adora with a rush of air, following Glimmer.

Desperately wishing she could kick something, Adora contented herself with releasing a loud stream of Horde-style profanity, something she had rarely done before in her life.

Distracted by frustration and despair, it took her a moment to realize Glimmer was leading them the wrong way. She had to be following planted information, which meant they were headed

right into whatever trap Catra had laid. Adora turned and ran after them.

"Wait, this doesn't make sense," Glimmer was saying as she caught up to them. "The map says the pit is right here."

The group spun, putting their backs together, as a pair of bots came clanking out of the shadows.

"We'll handle this, Flutterina," Bow said. "You stay out of sight."

The girl gulped and ran for cover.

Adora stood helplessly as her friends fought the bots, her entire body—entire *soul*—itching to kick and stab and slash beside them. She turned and glared at Flutterina, for all the good that did. At least the little spy wasn't doing anything to make things worse, yet.

"Wait, Swift Wind, these are the ones that regenerate!" Bow shouted—too late, as Swift Wind tore through a bot with his horn.

"Whoops!" Swift Wind cried, now dodging the two resulting bots.

Glimmer, who had managed to take out one bot with a judicious blast of magic to its head, wasn't as careful as she flung a ball of pink sparkles at one of Swift Wind's opponents. The bot broke apart from the force of the blast, and healed into two bots.

"Glimmer!" Bow yelped.

"Sorry!"

Bow fired some kind of trick arrow toward the eye of one bot, but it rotated its head just in time, the arrow glancing off metal. With a chill, Adora realized they were now surrounded, bots on every side.

But they weren't advancing any further. The bots had herded the Rebels to the center of a large metal plate. Now they stopped,

laser-eyes aimed, but not firing. Glimmer, Bow, and Swift Wind stood uneasily, poised to attack.

Catra came into sight on a gangway overhead, clapping with slow, deliberate movements. "Nice job, Sparkles! You've officially failed at everything you've tried to do today. How does that *feel*?"

Glimmer bared her teeth. "Better than you're going to feel when I'm done with you."

"Gotta admire that optimism," Catra snorted. "It won't help, though. You're not much of a threat without *She-Ra* to come to your rescue, are you?" Her gaze flicked toward Adora, standing amongst her friends, then away again.

"Yeah," Glimmer said, "congratulations on getting the only person who ever cared about you killed. How does that *feel*?"

The mocking smile dropped off Catra's face, and was replaced by a snarl. She raised a hand, and snapped her fingers.

The metal plate underfoot crackled to life, bolts of red lightning arcing across its surface. They all—except Adora—collapsed screaming to the ground.

"Pretty good, huh? I got the idea from Shadow Weaver," Catra called. Looking right at Adora, she added, "Wow, if only Adora could see you guys now!"

Adora couldn't feel the electricity, but she wished she could. It couldn't possibly hurt more than standing here, watching her friends convulse with pain. She tried to grab Glimmer and drag her away—tried Bow, tried Swift Wind. She knew it wouldn't work, and it didn't. She couldn't touch them. Couldn't do anything but sob as her friends screamed and spasmed around her.

"Catra!" She looked up at the gangway, and was there almost without meaning to be, right in Catra's face. "Catra, stop! Stop hurting them!"

"Or what?" Catra snarled.

On the ground below, Glimmer tried to teleport. The result was something very similar to her old "glitching," and she made a noise Adora never wanted to hear again.

"Are you seriously taking torture inspiration from Shadow Weaver?" Adora demanded. "How can you do that without feeling sick? Is that really the person you want to be?"

Catra moved forward, crowding Adora back a step. "I want to be the person who *wins*. I'll do whatever I need to. What are you going to do to stop me?"

Adora stared at her, glanced at her friends below, then back to Catra. She swallowed—and dropped to her knees.

"Please. Please, Catra. Stop hurting them. Please."

Catra stepped back, eyes wide. "What—are you—are you *begging*?" Anger roughened her voice. "You never begged Shadow Weaver to stop hurting me—but them, for *them* you'll beg—"

"I never begged Shadow Weaver because I knew it wouldn't help." Adora could feel tears streaming down her face. "It would only make her angrier. I knew she didn't have any mercy in her to give. *But you do*. You're a better person than her. Please, Catra."

Catra looked sick and shaken. For a long moment, she stared down at Adora.

Then she gestured to someone Adora couldn't see, a slicing motion across her throat, and the electricity cut off.

Adora was too stunned to get off her knees. Below, she could hear her friends panting and groaning as they staggered to their feet.

She and Catra stared at each other. Adora opened her mouth—

BOOM!

They both jumped, looking toward the noise. Flutterina, Adora realized, had climbed aboard Elberon's party cannon and set it off.

The air was filled with bits of paper, *thousands* of them, swooping and swirling in every direction. The bots surrounding the no-longer-electrified floor turned their heads frantically this way and that, their aiming tech confounded.

"What did that stupid pink butterfly do?" Catra shouted. "Get everything turned back on, now!" Another gesture, discreetly negating that order.

Adora stood up. "Thank you," she whispered, close enough they could have touched foreheads—oh, how she wished she could touch Catra right now. "Thank you."

Then she turned and jumped off the gangway, joining her friends as they evaded the bots and ran after Flutterina, who was shouting that she'd found where the villagers were being kept.

"Adora!" Catra cried, but Adora didn't dare look back. The roil of emotion in her chest was too confusing.

Adora… supervised, she supposed, as if it might help, as her friends freed the Elberon villagers and fought their way out of the Horde outpost. To her it was obvious that Catra was making it too easy for them to get away, but to her frustration, that didn't seem to occur to any of the others.

Finally they reached the edge of the Whispering Woods, and the Horde pursuit abruptly stopped, as it usually did.

The tone of the group shifted from terror to relief, the villagers shepherding each other along, comforting their loved ones and tending minor injuries.

"I can't thank you enough for coming to our rescue," the mayor said to Bow and Glimmer as they picked their way through the forest. "I shudder to think what the Horde may have had in store for us."

"Thank Flutterina," Bow said, nudging the girl forward. "We never could have done it without her!"

"She really saved our bacon," Glimmer admitted. "She's the one who found where you were being kept, and disabled the trap the Horde sprang on us."

Flutterina turned even pinker, bashful and touched. Adora tried to punch her in the face, just for fun, but of course it didn't work.

"I had to do whatever I could," Flutterina said. "If—if you mean what you said—that my help meant that much—oh, I really want to join the Rebellion! I know you think I'm just a kid, but I wanna fight the Horde and keep my people safe, like—" her lip trembled "—like She-Ra did…"

"Oh, *fuck* you!" Adora shouted.

Swift Wind, on Glimmer's other side, abruptly stopped walking. Under his breath, he muttered, "There it is again."

Adora gasped, spinning toward him.

"There what is?" Glimmer asked.

Swift Wind glanced at Flutterina and the mayor. "You guys go ahead, I uh… need to talk about special Rebellion stuff for a second." He jerked his head, and led Glimmer and Bow a few steps away from the trail the Elberon villagers were following.

"Swiftie, what is it?" Bow asked.

"Look, I know what you're gonna say, but that's the second time today that I've heard Adora's voice."

To Adora's surprise, Bow and Glimmer barely reacted, only glancing at each other awkwardly.

"Okay," Glimmer sighed. "What was she saying?"

"Well, I didn't *exactly* hear her voice," Swift Wind said, shifting his weight. "But… almost? I could feel her presence, guys, I swear!"

"You did!" Adora cried. "It's me, Swift Wind, it's me!"

"Swift Wind…" Bow's expression was pitying.

"We have a *sacred bond*," Swift Wind said defensively.

"But we talked about this." Glimmer looked both impatient and pained. "It's grief, Swift Wind, it's a normal part of grief—like my mom talked about. Thinking she hears my dad's voice sometimes, even though it's been *years*."

"It's your mind wanting something so bad that it just… makes it up," Bow said.

"Adora's gone." Glimmer's voice had gone rough. "And we have to accept that she's gone. It doesn't do any good to fool ourselves."

"But," Swift Wind said, "but if we talked to Shadow Weaver, she might know something—"

"No," Glimmer snapped. "The person who made Adora more miserable than anyone else on Etheria? I don't think so."

"Queen Angella's forbidden any of us to talk to her, remember?" Bow said. "I'm not even sure where she's keeping her." He stepped forward and hugged Swift Wind's neck. "We miss her too, Swiftie. So much. Dreaming about her and 'feeling her presence,' that's normal. It doesn't mean she's here. You're just torturing yourself."

"I guess you're right," Swift Wind said, hanging his head.

"No," Adora wailed. "Don't listen to them! I'm here, I really am!"

But if Swift Wind heard her now, he gave no sign of it. Adora walked backwards in front of him all the way back to the trail, shouting at the top of her lungs. He never twitched an ear.

When they caught up with the villagers, Adora sat down in the middle of the trail and watched them slowly disappear into the shadows of the forest. Despair dragged at her, making the ever-hovering blank brightness awfully tempting—but it was getting so hard to come back from there that she didn't dare, not in a moment like this.

After a minute, she got up and turned back toward the Fright Zone. At least Catra could hear her.

And might even be starting to *listen*.

# Chapter 5

Catra hadn't been up here since Adora died, this spot that had once been *their* spot, high above the rest of the Fright Zone. She'd come sometimes, after Adora left the Horde, to cry or rage or just be alone. She was the one to find this spot, years ago, and show it to Adora; she told herself it was *her* spot, not theirs, and she wasn't going to let Adora's betrayal poison it for her. But somehow she hadn't felt much need to come here since Adora… reappeared. However that worked. It would have felt weird, anyway, to bring Adora's ghost, or memory, or whatever she was—like they were going back to how things were. And they weren't doing that. They couldn't.

But Adora was gone again now. And Catra didn't fool herself that she was coming back.

She closed her eyes, flinching away from her mind's replay of Adora running off with the Rebels without even looking back. Going back to her princess friends, the moment she had an opportunity. *Thank you*, she'd said, her eyes wet, and for just a second Catra thought it meant something. But no, it only meant *goodbye*. She'd let Adora confuse her, make her weak, and Adora had repaid it by betraying her again. Leaving her, again. Catra had looked down at Adora begging her, believing in her, and for one second let herself be vulnerable—and it cost her everything.

*It cost me* nothing, Catra corrected, feeling a snarl wrinkle her face. *She was probably never even real, and I'm way better off without a hallucination distracting me.*

"Catra, there you are!"

Scorpia. Catra closed her eyes and sighed.

"Are you okay? Hey, don't worry about those Rebels getting away. I'm here and there's nothing we can't fix, because that's what

friends are for. I'm sure Hordak will understand. Oh! If Entrapta was here maybe we could—"

Catra whirled. "Stop it! Stop badgering me, stop hovering over me, just *back off!"* The hurt on Scorpia's face pricked her, goading her into hotter anger. "I don't need to explain myself to you. We're not friends!" She stormed past Scorpia, back inside.

*You're losing her*. Barely a whisper, maybe only her own thoughts, except that it sounded like Adora's voice. *You're going to lose Scorpia if you don't treat her better*.

*So what?* Catra thought as she stalked away through the metal corridors. *Why should Scorpia be any different than anyone else?*

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She talked to Hordak—who was, if not pleased by the cost in bots of putting Double Trouble into place, at least willing to let the strategy play out. She dealt with supply problems, and training problems, and discipline problems that *no one* wanted escalated to Hordak. And eventually, with the position of the moons signalling far too little time before daylight, she went to bed.

By then, Catra's anger at Adora had flickered out. She hated when even anger abandoned her, hated the yawning black hole it left behind—a hole she couldn't afford to look into, and refused to name.

Alone in her quarters, where no one would ever know what she said or did, Catra pretended her voice was steady as she called, "Adora?"

No answer, of course.

After she'd gotten back from the Crimson Waste, there had been no answer for days. She had thought Adora was never coming back that time, and then she had—was just there one morning when Catra woke up, sitting next to the bed and humming to herself. But that time Adora hadn't actually *turned her back and*

*run away* from Catra. She hadn't had her stupid princess friends to go back to.

Catra stood in front of the mirror, examining the reflection of the room behind her. But Adora wasn't there.

Catra's head dropped, leaning against the mirror. "You're not real anyway," she whispered. "You *died*. I remember how it felt in the portal—the coming apart. It didn't hurt, exactly." Her breath caught. "I hope it didn't hurt."

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"It didn't."

Catra opened her eyes a slit. "What?" she said, barely awake enough to form the word.

Adora was next to her in the bed, their heads on the same pillow. "You asked if it hurt," she said softly. "It didn't."

"You… you came back."

"Yeah."

Catra swallowed and turned her face into the pillow. "Then you're definitely not real. Adora doesn't come back for me. She never will."

No response. Catra opened her eyes again, a little surprised to find Adora still there, her expression troubled.

"You're just a dream," Catra sighed. "You don't even look real. I can see through you."

"It's getting harder," Adora murmured. "Being here."

"I do dream about you a lot." Words flowed out of her, and she wasn't awake enough to stop them. "I dream you've come home. Or I dream you're putting a sword through me. Or both. Or… sometimes better dreams. Maybe this is one of those. They're a

bitch to wake up from, but until I do…" Clumsy with sleep, she reached out and cradled Adora's cheek in her palm. Transparent or not, it felt warm and solid.

Adora's eyes widened. Catra was too sleepy to understand why. Without stopping to think, she shifted forward and kissed Adora on the mouth.

Adora gasped, the sound jolting Catra awake. She scrambled upright, rubbing her eyes.

Adora, if she had ever been there, was gone.

# Chapter 6

Catra didn't see Adora for two days, after the kiss. She almost convinced herself it was entirely a dream, but then she started catching glimpses of Adora in mirrors again. Well, it was still probably a dream, right? Adora was something cooked up by her own brain and probably always had been.

Maybe Catra's waning belief in the delusion was why Adora seldom spoke now. She hadn't looked solid once since the Elberon trap. Catra only heard her voice when she was half-asleep, which was surely confirmation that she was just dreaming their conversations anyway. When they talked, they talked about the past, old jokes, old secrets. Once, after a long silence, Adora tried to thank her for turning off the lightning field for her friends. Catra snapped at her to shut up.

Catra didn't try to kiss her again. Adora had vanished last time, as if fleeing from it. And Adora never asked about it, never brought it up.

Even when she was a figment of Catra's own imagination, Adora didn't want her.

At least things were going well for the Horde. The regenerating bots had proven too expensive to manufacture any more of, but a new design called the pulse bot proved *very* useful. Double Trouble was gleefully feeding Catra information on the Rebellion's plans, as well as steadily driving wedges between the Rebellion leaders—especially Princess Glimmer and Queen Angella, who apparently had a rocky relationship at the best of times. Every small victory for the Horde won them more resources to put toward the *big* victory—the Sea Gate at Salineas, a plan so ambitious Catra and Hordak had hardly dared to speak of it except to each other.

Catra especially tried not to mention it if Adora was listening.

Not that Adora, being nothing but a hallucination, could have done anything to stop it. But it seemed that every time Catra gave a triumphant update to Hordak, she could see Adora looking at her sadly from a reflection somewhere nearby. She didn't need that to get any worse. It was annoying.

Adora bestirred herself to speak during the day for the first time in two weeks, after a particularly successful ambush that ended with Arrow Boy being carted away on a stretcher.

"Just find out if he's okay," Adora pleaded from the mirror. Catra had gotten strange looks for insisting on installing a mirror in her bare-bones chamber, in the Whispering Woods cave where the pulse bots were headquartered, but no one had dared say anything outright. "Please, Catra."

"What are you gonna do about it if he's not?" Catra scoffed, but picked up the tracker pad she used to communicate with Double Trouble. Adora was talking to her again; she wasn't going to say 'no' to anything she wanted right now. Nor was she going to examine that sentiment *at all*. "Fine, but keep your mouth shut during the call, Double Trouble's seen me talking to empty rooms too many times already."

"Oh, the boy's going to live," Double Trouble said airily, when Catra got through to them. "Probably. He won't be on the field again for a good long time, though. Glimmer is in hysterics about it." They did their usual theatrical impressions—Glimmer sobbing her eyes out, Bow wheezing a last will and testament in which he left his arrows to Flutterina before fainting melodramatically away. Catra laughed, but somehow it wasn't as funny with Adora watching, her mouth a thin line.

"In fact, the incident provided another chance to disturb mother-daughter harmony," Double Trouble said, in their own form. "A

chance I took, of course, but it occurred to me afterward that it might backfire. Flutterina encouraged Glimmer to go see your old commanding officer, against Mother's orders, and see what *she* can do to help poor Bow."

"Shadow Weaver?" Catra frowned, uneasy. "I don't think healing magic is in her repertoire."

Double Trouble shrugged. "Well, whatever *is* in her repertoire, it might be in Glimmer's soon enough."

Double Trouble was right to warn them. The next day, with the cave nearly emptied by what was, in retrospect, a distraction-attack staged elsewhere by the other princesses, Glimmer teleported in on top of them, smelling like one of Shadow Weaver's tracking spells.

Catra was good at evasive action, but still had more than one close call in the first few seconds, Glimmer's sparkling pink blasts taking chunks out of supplies, equipment, and even the stone walls. The few other soldiers in the cave ran for cover, but Glimmer ignored them, focusing only on Catra. Oh good, this was going to be a *challenge*.

"Oh, is someone upset about their boyfriend getting hurt?" Catra called sweetly.

"Bow's going to live," Glimmer said, "unlike you," and the nimbus of her next blast burned the edges of Catra's hair. It melted the pulse bot behind her, and Catra repressed a thoroughly stupid urge to shout a warning to Adora, whom she'd seen reflected on that bot a few minutes before.

"Didn't anyone ever teach you to put away your toys?" Glimmer shouted, blasting the only other visible bot. "Otherwise, someone might come and *break them*."

"You think I don't have more?" Catra sneered.

"I think most of them are getting obliterated by the Princess Alliance, leaving you defenseless."

Catra laughed. "Wow, you're using *strategy*? I didn't realize you knew how!"

"Guess you don't know everything," Glimmer said. Catra just had time to realize that the reason she hadn't fired again was that she was building up a bigger charge—just as Glimmer teleported up onto the gangway where Catra was hiding, and released it.

Catra leaped off the gangway, deploying her whip as she fell to wrap around Glimmer's ankle. *If I'm going down, you're going down with me*.

Glimmer yelped, losing control of her extra-powerful blast—which ripped across the far wall, swallowing half the cave in explosions. Catra turned a hard landing into a controlled tumble, catching a glimpse of her soldiers making a run for it in the absence of other orders. Good. That opened up her options.

And then Glimmer was on top of her in a burst of sparkles. Catra struggled, bit Glimmer's hand—"ugh, you even *taste* like glitter"—and twisted away, even managed to wrap her whip around the princess's arm while she was readying another blast. *That* backfired, unfortunately, energy traveling down the whip and slamming Catra against the wall with her fur singed and standing on end. Clearly, going to hand-to-hand with a princess was a bad idea, no matter how much fun it was. Catra darted for the nearest bot console.

"Where are you going, Catra? Not scared of some sparkles, are you?" Glimmer stalked after her, magic gathering around her fists.

"The pulse bots are out vaporizing your friends," Catra said conversationally, "but maybe you'd like to see our upgrade? We were saving it for a special occasion, but this'll do."

The metal container beside her opened, revealing their prototype next-level pulse bot, twice the size of the others. It began drilling

into the floor, preparing to fire—not something designed to be done *indoors*. The already-damaged cave shook like an earthquake, boxes tumbling and cables snapping overhead.

"You're gonna bring the whole place down!" Glimmer cried.

"Don't worry, I'm not planning to stick around!" Catra jumped past Glimmer, toward the exit. "It's revving up to send out a pulse strong enough to level half the woods. So you'd better choose. Me, or the bot?"

Pleased with herself, she turned her back on the furious princess—oh, it felt good to make someone *that angry* and that totally powerless to act on it—and dashed for the exit.

Only for a blast of magic to smash into the beam directly overhead, bringing it down on top of her. Terror lit Catra's body as she realized she wasn't going to dodge it in time.

*"Catra!"*

The voice was faint, but the hands shoving Catra were firm and solid. More than hands—an entire body, tackling her out of the way of the falling beam, shielding her as they tumbled across the cave floor.

Dust billowed and then cleared from the beam's impact. "Adora?" Catra whispered, an invisible weight still pinning her down.

She could have sworn she felt just a moment's pressure against her forehead, a brush of breath across her face. And then it was gone.

With a scream of frustration that made Catra jump, Glimmer teleported the about-to-blow pulse bot out of the cave. Catra ran before she could come back.

---

Double Trouble, of all people, gave Catra a ride back to the Fright Zone—they'd just been arriving at the cave when Catra made it

out, having come to warn her about Glimmer.

*See, Adora? They're not* just *bought*, Catra wanted to say, but even if she could have said it aloud, there was no sign of Adora in even the shiniest metal plates on the skiff.

Then she had to deal with placating Hordak about the equipment losses, which she managed handily with, "Yeah, turns out the pulse bots are garbage. The princesses took them out in seconds. Good thing we found that out before using them for the Big Plan."

Finally she had a moment alone—but she wanted to be *truly* alone for this, and now that Scorpia had found her rooftop spot, it was hard to think of anywhere she could count on staying uninterrupted. Even her personal quarters were much too vulnerable to Scorpia's poking around.

Well, she could think of one place no one in the Fright Zone had any reason or desire to go. Shadow Weaver's old lair, the Black Garnet Chamber.

She slipped in and closed the door behind her soundlessly, as if Shadow Weaver might still descend on her like a hawk, delivering pain and demanding obedience. The room was musty and dim, a fine layer of dust gathering on all its surfaces. No, not all—on the various pieces of tech attached to the Garnet, yes, but the runestone itself was as clean and polished as if it had been wiped down every day. *That* wasn't unsettling at all.

Catra leaned back against the wall and took a deep breath.

"Adora?"

Her voice disturbed the stillness of the chamber like a stone dropped into water, echoing faintly in the furthest recesses of the ceiling. But when the echoes faded, the silence returned. Adora didn't answer.

Catra forced more words out—thinking aloud more than anything else, but determined not to be intimidated into silence by an

empty room. "This might work better if I could lay down and get sleepy. It seems to be easier for you then. But I can't get caught napping right now, and anyway, I don't think I'd ever be able to relax enough in here. This place still gives me the heebie-jeebies." She looked around, thinking of all the times she'd been slammed against that wall, told to kneel on that floor, held helpless or outright tortured by dark crackling magic.

"Our childhood really sucked," she murmured to the empty room where Adora probably wasn't listening. "It wasn't all bad, though… thanks to you. All the good parts were because of you." She closed her eyes, swallowed. "And then you left me. And that… broke something, Adora, just to know you were *willing* to leave me. You wanted me to come with you, sure, but you were leaving whether I came along or not. I don't know how to explain what that did to me." Her voice misbehaved in the last sentence, rough and wavering. She clenched her mouth shut, fighting to regain control.

*I never stopped loving you*. She couldn't begin to imagine actually saying that out loud. *I wanted to, I tried to, but it didn't work.*

"I tried to replace you," she said instead, when she could speak again. "Sometimes I thought it had worked, because Scorpia and —and Entrapta… They're not you, but they're… they're…" Ugh, she didn't know the word to use. "Well, it doesn't matter now. I can't even have a civil conversation with Scorpia anymore—I don't know why, I don't know how to stop being awful to her—and *Entrapta*—" Her voice caught on a sob, catching her by surprise, but it didn't matter. Adora wasn't here, no one was listening.

"I hurt everyone I try to love." She could barely force the words out, even as a whisper. "The last thing I said to you, before you died, was telling you every horrible thing I did was *your* fault, knowing you've always felt responsible for me. I just wanted to hurt you. I've tried so hard to prove Shadow Weaver wrong about me, but I think I'm mostly proving her right. I really am worthless."

"No, you're not."

Catra gasped, looking up. Only a few feet away, reflected in the glossy surface of the Black Garnet, was Adora.

"You've never been worthless, Catra," Adora said stoutly, almost angrily. "Even when I hate what you're doing—which is mostly, these days—you're damn good at it. And even if you were the world's worst Force Captain, so what? There's so much more to the world than that! Did you know, in Bright Moon, there are people who just make pictures? They just make beautiful things to look at, all day, that's all they do! They can't fight worth spit, and no one cares. They're not worthless, and neither are you."

"You sure sound real." Catra let Adora's voice pull her across the room, toward the Garnet—but she drew back before her fingers touched the surface, wary of making contact with a runestone. "I couldn't make up the kind of nonsense you're spouting. And you look real. You look more real than *I* do." She cocked her head, studying what she saw; her own reflection was dim and shadowy, Adora's bright and clear over it, as if the surface of the Garnet were a window instead of a mirror.

"I'm real," Adora said impatiently, "and I'm telling you you are the furthest thing from worthless."

"I really had convinced myself you were all in my head," Catra said. "But today, in the cave—I felt you. You moved me out of the way, when I wouldn't have made it. I don't know what to believe now."

Adora looked at her sadly. "Why don't you want to believe I'm real?"

Catra gave an unsteady laugh. "Because then I'd have to be angry at you again."

Adora blinked in surprise. "What do you mean?"

"There's no point being angry at a figment of my own imagination. I can just…" *Just enjoy having you around*. Her cheeks warmed from admitting that much even to herself. "But if you're really *you*, then… then everything that stood between us is still there."

"It doesn't have to be." Adora sounded pleading.

"Yes, it does," Catra snapped, temper sparking. "You think the past is going to change just because you don't want to deal with it? You still did what you did, and I've still done what I've done, and neither of us can go back." Another shaky laugh. "We tried that, didn't we? The portal tried to give us what we wanted. But it all fell apart. It always will."

"We can't go back," Adora said, "but we can go forward."

"Forward how?" This time Catra's laugh was a little nasty. "Even if you're real, Adora, you're *dead*. There's nowhere to go from there. Well, for most people—you, even when you're dead, still manage to abandon me."

"What? When did I—"

"Elberon." Catra spat the word before she could think better of it, think about how much vulnerability she was revealing. It wasn't even quite correct—they hadn't been in Elberon, the prisoners had just been *from* Elberon—but Adora got the idea anyway.

"I did, didn't I?" Adora murmured, frowning. "I didn't even look back. I was so focused on trying to make my friends hear me… I did come back! But the whole thing—trying to be real enough for them to see, and all the teleporting or whatever I did—I was so tired, I couldn't really come back all the way. Until here, where it's easier." She stepped forward again, and pressed her hand against the surface of the Garnet, again as if it were a window between them. "I'm sorry, Catra," she said, soft and earnest. "I'm so sorry."

"Apologies," Catra snorted. "Too little, too late, Adora." She turned away, arms crossed as if to hold in all the emotions churning in

her chest.

Adora's voice rose, frustrated. "Well, I'm here now! What do you want from me, Catra? You want me to leave?"

"No!" Catra clawed at her hair. "I don't want you to leave. I even want you to be real, in spite of everything. Because I guess I enjoy making everything worse for myself." Reluctantly, she turned back to face Adora. "Can you prove you're real?"

"Ask me anything," Adora offered uncertainly.

Catra thought a minute, but—"No, that won't work. Any secret you dig up from our childhood, I already know it. You could still be a figment of my brain."

Adora huffed in frustration. "But anything you don't already know would have to come from after I left, and you would have no way to verify… Wait." She bit her lip, hesitating over whatever idea she was having, for a long moment. "There's, um… there's one thing. A letter. I hid it in my room in Bright Moon, I doubt the others found it, even if they cleared out the rest of my stuff. Double Trouble could bring it to you."

Something no one knew about but Adora. That would definitely be proof, if it was there. The idea made Catra's chest tighten. "Where is it hidden?"

"Inside the frame of a mirror." She described the location in detail, twice, with Catra repeating it back to her so she'd have it memorized to tell Double Trouble.

"Why did you hide it? Who is it f—Adora?" Catra almost touched the Garnet, alarmed by the way Adora had just flickered.

"I'm fine," Adora said, too briskly.

"You flickered. I've never seen you do that before." Catra bit her lip. "You're tired. It's gotten harder for you, being visible."

"It's easier here." Adora looked around thoughtfully. "Easier to focus. I feel more real."

"Easier. But still not easy. Am I right?"

Adora shrugged, which was as good as a yes.

"Earlier, you actually made yourself *solid*—you've got to be exhausted." The only other time she'd been tangible for even a moment was—

Catra flushed and tried to steer her mind firmly away from how it had felt to kiss Adora, for just that one half-asleep fraction of a second.

"I can't stay any longer," Adora admitted. "Come back to this room and call for me, when Double Trouble finds the letter." Her voice was getting fainter.

"Don't go yet," Catra said desperately, and was trying to think of a reason, any reason for Adora to stay, when a realization distracted her. "You're a reflection again."

"What?"

"Before, you didn't look like a reflection. It almost looked like you were standing *inside* the Black Garnet, like it was just a sheet of glass between us. But now you're a reflection again, like you're standing behind me."

"Oh," Adora said, as if that explained something, but she didn't explain. Her reflection stepped up closer behind Catra's, peering over her shoulder.

A pale imitation of closeness—yet Catra's heart was pounding anyway. Hesitantly, eyes locked on their reflections, she reached backward for Adora's hand.

She didn't feel anything, but in the mirrored surface she saw Adora return the grasp. Her breath caught.

Without speaking, Adora shifted closer, until Catra should have been able to feel her against her back. Then she folded her arms around Catra from behind, still holding Catra's hand so that her arm pressed against her own chest. She couldn't have said whether she moved it there of her own volition or not. She couldn't feel Adora, but she could *see* her, right there, holding her. Never looking away, Catra turned her head just enough that, in the mirror, her forehead was touching the side of Adora's face.

"Call for me from this room," Adora whispered, "and I'll answer. I promise."

Catra closed her eyes. *Please be real. Please be real*.

When she opened them, she was alone in the mirror.

# Chapter 7

Chapter Notes

> I know everyone is expecting That Letter and that was my original intention, but when I actually looked at what it said, That Letter has very much a vibe of being written after the loss of Angella. Which never happened in this AU. So I wrote my own letter, though I kept a few of my favorite lines from the original.

Catra felt like she was crawling out of her skin every hour that she waited for Double Trouble to find the letter—and there were a lot of hours, one day becoming two and then three. She wouldn't let herself pester Double Trouble half as much as she wanted to, and she wouldn't let herself go back into the Black Garnet Chamber, or call for Adora at all. Adora needed to *rest*. That much had been obvious.

She couldn't help whispering "Goodnight, Adora" into the empty darkness of her quarters before she went to sleep at night. But if there was any answer, she didn't hear it.

Maybe Adora really was just a delusion, and this attempt to prove her real had broken the dream. It would follow the pattern of her life, for her to lose Adora again just when she'd let herself hope, a little bit.

*And if she is real? Then what?* Catra stared at her ceiling. *What are either of you supposed to do about it?*

She tried to keep herself busy getting ready for the Salineas invasion; preparations were reaching a fever pitch. Catra suspected a few people had put together what was happening, though she still hadn't announced it. She leaned heavily on her old squad for the sudden emergencies that kept popping up; the three of them were assigned to her specifically, which made it convenient, and she knew she could depend on their discretion

and competence. They weren't getting a lot of rest in between emergencies, but neither was Catra. She'd make it up to them afterward, when there was glory and praise to be spread around.

On the third day since telling Double Trouble to find the letter, she called her spy on the tracker pad only to get more excuses.

"From what you've told me, Bright Moon can't even guard their prisoners properly," she snarled, "and you're telling me you can't find a way to sneak into an empty bedroom?"

"I need to have enough time to poke around," Double Trouble said patiently. "And sneak back out again. And it's not as if I don't have any other priorities—"

"You don't," Catra said. "This is your priority until I have that letter in my hand."

Double Trouble pursed their lips and put their hands up in a casual 'surrender' gesture. "All right, then. You're the boss, kitten."

"Don't forget it," Catra said. "Oh, and Double Trouble?"

"Yes?"

"When you find the letter, *don't* read it." Catra switched off the pad.

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A few hours later, she still hadn't heard from Double Trouble, she'd discovered three new supply problems, she'd had a run-in with Entrapta's pet bot that put her nerves on edge, and one of the *old* supply problems that was supposed to be fixed hadn't been.

"Where are you?" she barked into her pad, the moment it made contact with her squad's transport, which was apparently still in the Whispering Woods. "You were supposed to be back an hour ago."

Kyle stammered. "Well, the woods are attacking us with very painful snow," he said, and ducked behind Rogelio.

"Why is he talking?" Catra said, and thankfully Lonnie stepped forward.

"There's some sort of weird acid storm happening out there," she said, clear and professional as always. "But we're assessing the situation."

"Assess faster! Hordak needs that armor plating from the rebel mine, now. The plan can't fall behind schedule." She hoped to the skies that she didn't sound as panicked as she felt.

"Well, maybe if you told us what this big plan is, we could help you—"

"I doubt that, seeing as you failed to do the one thing I asked!" What had she just been thinking, about trusting her squad's competence? Now, of all times, they had to drop the ball?

"Hey. It's not our fault." Lonnie kept her tone calm and even. "The transport broke down, and it's too dangerous to go out there."

*"I don't care!* I gave you an order!" Catra stopped dead in the midst of drawing breath for more. Kyle was peering around Rogelio's arm, and suddenly Catra remembered what Adora had said about the people in Bright Moon who couldn't fight, and no one cared because they made beautiful things instead. That was the sort of thing Kyle ought to be doing.

*They're not worthless, and neither are you*, Adora had said.

But she was treating them—her squad—like they were worthless, and they were all looking at her exactly the way she used to look at Shadow Weaver, when she knew she was being punished unfairly and had no choice but to endure it.

Catra took a deep breath, her squad watching warily, and tried again.

"Is this acid storm damaging the transport?" she asked.

"Yes," Lonnie answered.

"Then sitting still might get you killed. Better to get the transport running and try to get out of it."

"The acid spores eat right through our armor if we try to go out there." Lonnie was still calm—not arguing with her, Catra realized, but presenting the problem.

"Use the new plating from the rebel mine. It should hold up longer."

"But," Kyle squeaked, "don't you need that? I mean, you won't be mad—?"

"If you lot get the whole transport eaten up with acid, I won't get any of that new armor, will I?" Catra couldn't help sounding impatient, but she wasn't yelling. "Better to lose one plate than all of it. *One* plate better be sufficient."

"It will be," Lonnie said.

"Good. I want you guys here within the hour, preferably with a minimum of injuries. I can't afford to have you out of commission. Understand?"

"Yes, Force Captain Catra. And—thank you." Lonnie's expression was strange, almost impressed, her spine straighter than usual. Catra looked at her, wary; Lonnie inclined her head in a silent nod, and Catra had the funniest feeling that she understood more than Catra wanted her to.

Catra nodded back, jerkily, and cut the comm.

---

Catra was bent over paperwork, trying to understand a new bot design well enough to order the right supplies for its manufacture, when Scorpia walked into her office.

"Hey, so, not-so-great news," she said, wincing. "The Rebellion just took the West Canyon outpost."

Catra sighed, barely looking up. "Yeah, I'm not surprised. It won't be the last."

"Um… and we're okay with that?"

"That outpost was down to a skeleton crew. I didn't expect them to last in a real fight—in fact, their orders were to retreat as soon as it became clear they were facing a superior force."

"Oh, good," Scorpia said, letting out a gusty breath. "I was too nervous to tell you they'd retreated."

Catra gave her a sharp look. "Scorpia, you better not *ever* be withholding information from me, no matter how nervous you are."

"Of course not! I mean, nothing important, but—I'm sure there's things you'd rather I didn't bother you with…"

Catra clamped her teeth on an irritated response. Scorpia's cringing always made her impatient, yes, but… it wasn't fair to blame Scorpia for being afraid to bother Catra, when she'd yelled at her for it so often.

*I can't even have a civil conversation with Scorpia anymore and I don't know why*, she'd told Adora. *I hurt everyone I try to love*.

And the voice that might or might not have been Adora's. *You're going to lose Scorpia if you don't treat her better*.

Catra felt a flutter of panic in her chest at the very idea of losing Scorpia.

"Sit down," Catra said, cutting off Scorpia's nervous prattle. "I want to talk to you."

"You—you do?" Scorpia actually looked over her shoulder, as if Catra might mean someone else.

"Yeah. Shut the door."

Scorpia shut the door and pulled a second chair up to Catra's desk, nearly tipping over first the chair and then the desk.

"What did you want to talk about? Ooh, are you ready to tell me about the big plan you've been so busy with? You know I've got your back, whatever you need help with!"

"I don't need help," Catra snapped reflexively.

The smile slid off Scorpia's face. "Oh… then… Did I do something wrong? Is that it?"

She was looking at Catra like her team had looked at her. Like Catra had looked at the only mother she'd ever had, back when she still felt some kind of hope of pleasing her.

*Shadow Weaver didn't have any mercy in her to give*, Adora had said. *But you do*.

"When I was growing up," Catra said, her voice brisk and abrupt because she didn't know how else to be, "Shadow Weaver took everything out on me. If she was angry, or frustrated, or disappointed, or just stressed out, it was always my fault, no matter what I did or didn't do. Any time she needed a scapegoat, there I was."

"Oh." Scorpia looked startled and sad. "I knew Shadow Weaver was never, like, a cuddly person—she always seemed pretty terrifying—but I figured with you and Ad—uh, with people close to her, she was probably different."

"With Adora, she was different. With me, she was worse."

Scorpia was looking genuinely upset. "That's awful. No kid deserves to be treated that way. And I remember seeing you

around as a little kitten—gosh, you were cute as a button. You deserved a lot better than that."

She said it so easily, like it was obvious. Catra looked away, throat tightening; she had to clear it before she could speak. "Well. I think I've been doing the same thing—using you as a scapegoat. And you deserve better than that, too. So I'm going to try not to do that anymore."

Scorpia was silent for so long that Catra finally dared a sideways glance at her. Scorpia's mouth was hanging a little open, her eyes wet.

"Thank you, Catra," she said softly.

Catra cleared her throat again. "That's all I wanted to say, so, you can go now."

"Sure, sure. Say, when you're done here, do you want to go hang out or—"

"You can go now," Catra repeated, louder, and Scorpia jumped up from her seat.

"Right, yeah, I'll give you some space. We've both got plenty to do, after all." She moved the chair back where it had been, knocked it over, set it back upright, and opened the door.

There was a bot waiting in the hallway, one that perked up at the sight of Scorpia, then saw Catra and recoiled. Emily. Entrapta's pet bot.

"All this bot stuff sure would be easier," Catra said, looking down at her manufacturing paperwork, "if Entrapta were here."

Scorpia lit up, spinning around. "I—Yeah, yeah, I agree!"

"I…" Catra trailed off. Was there any way in the world she could bring Entrapta back from Beast Island without revealing what

she'd done? Was Entrapta even still alive? "Well, I have a lot to get done, here," she said lamely.

"Sure. We can… talk about stuff later." Sickeningly hopeful, Scorpia walked out.

And crossed paths with a soldier in full armor, visor down, who walked right into Catra's office and hitched their hip onto the corner of her desk.

"Excuse me?" Catra said.

"Oh, you're excused, honey," Double Trouble drawled from behind the visor. With the usual blur of black and green, they shifted back to their usual form, and pulled something out of a vest pocket. "I brought you a present," they said, and with a flourish, set a folded paper on the desk.

---

Adora had no idea how much time had passed since she let the bright silence take her, in the Black Garnet Chamber. It might have been moments, it might have been weeks, drifting without thought or awareness. It was a chilling realization to come to, as she suddenly became conscious of herself again.

"Adora?"

Catra's voice. That was what had woken her. She had promised to answer, no matter how hard it was. Whatever amount of rest she'd gotten had helped, she thought as she began pulling herself into focus. The location, too—she'd been truthful when she said it was easier in the Black Garnet Chamber. In the Garnet itself, really; it seemed to pull her in, like a marble rolling into a dent in the floor, and hold her cradled. Less apt to drift away.

It was still hard.

"Adora!" Catra was starting to sound worried. Adora redoubled her efforts.

Finally she blinked clouds of light out of her eyes, and found herself in the same chamber she had left. Catra was standing in front of her.

"There you are," Catra said, shoulders dropping with relief. "Sure took your time."

Adora's gaze snagged on the creased paper in Catra's hand, and all breath left her lungs. "You found it."

Catra swallowed. "Yeah."

"You read it?"

"Yeah." Catra looked… shocky, almost, tense as a bowstring. Adora was suddenly horribly nervous about what could have been in that letter to upset her so much.

"I… I don't remember exactly what that one said," she admitted. "I think it started with talking about Glimmer's diary?"

Catra swallowed again, and held up the letter.

"*Dear Catra*," she read.

*"Glimmer writes in a diary. I write letters to you. Mostly I burn them. I don't want anyone to find them. To Glimmer, Bow and Angella, you're the enemy. They know we used to be friends, but they don't really understand. You were so much more than just my friend. I worry that if they really understood that, they would doubt my loyalty to the Rebellion—or just think I was crazy, to be that attached to you, of all people. They're not very impressed with you. I'm impressed, though. I always knew you could be amazing if anyone gave you a chance. You're as good a fighter as I am, and better at strategy. I just wish we were on the same side.*

*"I miss you every day. I miss your smile. I miss the gleam in your eye when you would beat me in a race during training. I miss*

*laughing with you when we would play pranks in the barracks. I miss having you with me at night—it's so hard to sleep all alone.*

*"I have to believe that we won't be separated forever. Someday, you'll join me here, and see how wonderful it is. That's what I think about when I can't sleep—the day we'll be together again. I hope it's soon.*

*"Love, Adora."*

She was silent for a long moment, lifting her gaze slowly from the letter to Adora.

Adora shifted nervously, tugging at her ponytail and wondering if the heat in her face was visible. "Yeah, that's… that's the one. And it was right where I said it would be, right? So you know… you know it's me. It's really me."

"*Love, Adora*," Catra repeated, barely a whisper. "How—how did you mean that? As… as a friend, right?"

Oh, this was exactly what Adora had spent *weeks* now trying to figure out. Well, no, she knew the answer to the question, she just didn't know what to *do* about it. She didn't want to make things worse with Catra, but it also seemed horrible not to tell her how she felt. Catra ought to know she was loved. She deserved that, even if she didn't reciprocate.

"Yes? But… no? I mean yes, but not *just* that?" Adora winced, rubbing her forehead. Words spilled out in a rush. "Look, I know it doesn't really mean anything that you tried to kiss me. You were mostly asleep, you probably don't even remember it. I don't want to make you uncomfortable. It's just, that's when I realized…? Of course I knew that I loved you, but I hadn't really—really realized—and I probably shouldn't have told you this at all, you don't have to do anything about it, I just—"

Catra cut her off with a sharp hand gesture. Her expression was—strange, somewhere between disbelief and fury. "You idiot," she said. "I've been in love with you since before I knew how to tie

my shoes. I've wanted you since I was old enough to want anything."

Adora made a strangled noise.

Catra stepped closer to the Garnet. Adora pressed her hands against the surface, and imagined she could almost, *almost* feel Catra's hands when she did the same.

"You love me?" Adora said unevenly. "Really?"

"More than anything in the world. How can that be a surprise?"

"Well, you haven't exactly been gentle with me when we've fought."

"You haven't, either. I've had more than one broken rib thanks to you." Catra didn't sound angry—closer to impressed. Well, they'd never pulled their punches in training, maybe it was unfair to expect it in combat. And while things had certainly reached a new pitch of viciousness since Adora switched sides, she couldn't pretend she didn't know why.

"I want to treat you better than that," Adora said, soft and stumbling, unsure how put it into words. "I want to *hold* you, I want…" She curled a hand where it was mirroring Catra's, running her knuckles down it as if to stroke her palm.

Catra snatched her hands back and scrubbed her face with them. "You love me. And you're real, you're really here. But there's nothing we can *do* about it. You're a—a *ghost* and you're going to leave me again, aren't you, even if you don't want to. You keep getting weaker. One day you just won't have the strength to come back anymore."

"I don't know," Adora said desperately. "It's so much easier, as long as I stay in here—I feel so *close* to real, like I'm just a few steps away, like the runestone is a door and if I could just open it, I could walk right through. Back into reality, back into the world.

But I can't *open* it." She smacked a fist against the unyielding surface of the Garnet.

"I can't either," Catra said slowly. "But maybe I know someone who could."

# Chapter 8

"Uh, wildcat, are we doing something with the Black Garnet? Does this have something to do with bringing Entrapta back? 'Cause," Scorpia laughed nervously, "I don't know what you think *I'll* be able to do. I'm not exactly a tech wiz…"

Catra, who had hauled Scorpia down to the Black Garnet Chamber in a mad rush, found all her hurry evaporating into nerves as she stared at the closed door to the chamber. She smoothed her hair and turned to face Scorpia.

"No, you're not a tech wiz," she said. "What you are is the princess of the Black Garnet."

"Well, yeah," Scorpia said uneasily, "but only technically? I mean, I've never had any connection to it. Shadow Weaver even dragged me in here once, as a kid, to test that out, and—nope, didn't feel a thing. Fortunately. I mean, it would have been useful, sure, but I got the impression Shadow Weaver wouldn't have really wanted to share."

"Well, she's not here to scare you away from it now," Catra said. "This runestone is yours by right, Scorpia. And you're correct, it would be *really* useful for you to be able to access it. Like, particularly useful right now."

"Ooh, for the big plan?"

"Um, something like that."

"I… I don't know, Catra." Scorpia took a step back from the door. "I don't think I'm really the magic powers type, you know? It's just not… it's not me. That's not the kind of thing I can do."

"Why not?"

Scorpia cringed some more, shifting her pincers in a way that might have counted as hand-wringing in someone else. "I'm the

muscle, wildcat. You know that. I'm good at picking things up and knocking things down, but to do this kind of thing—to be a princess, a *real* princess—I mean, you have to be really special for that."

Catra narrowed her eyes. "Scorpia, you are just as good as any princess out there," she said impatiently. "You're brave, loyal, and one heck of a fighter. Would I be bringing you here if I didn't think you could do it? Maybe it won't work, but it won't be because you're not *worthy* or something. That's not even a question."

"Really?" Scorpia's expression was far too goopy for Catra's comfort.

Catra blew hard through her nose. "Just try it, will you?"

Scorpia bit her lip and looked at the door. "I… Okay. I did, one time, almost feel like, maybe…" She took a deep breath. "Yeah, sure, I'll give it a try. Can't hurt, right?"

"Right." Catra hesitated again, reaching for the door. Should she tell Scorpia about Adora, about what this was really about? No, there was no way Scorpia would believe her. She would think Catra had lost her mind.

She opened the door.

"Oh my gosh, is that *Adora*?" Scorpia clapped a pincer over her mouth as if to hold in the forbidden word. "I mean, uh—it sure looks like—it's definitely a person, anyway. Right?"

"You can *see* her?"

"Well, yeah, she's right there! Pretty faint, like she's underwater or something, but yeah, I definitely see her."

"No one but Catra's been able to see me before!" Adora pressed against the surface of the Garnet, desperately excited.

"Oh, it—it looks like she's talking? I can't hear her, though," Scorpia said. Adora sagged with disappointment.

"I can hear her," Catra said. "I've been hearing her, and seeing her, for… a while now."

"Ohhh," Scorpia said. "That… that explains a few things. Unless—is she always in here? With the Garnet?"

"No," Catra said, and wondered exactly what *things* Scorpia was talking about. She thought she'd mostly avoided reacting to Adora when other people were around. Mostly. "No, she's not usually in here. But we discovered it's less tiring for her, to stay in here."

"Hold up, so you're like, a ghost?" Scorpia said to Adora. "Or—no, that's stupid. You're not dead at all, right? You're just stuck between dimensions or something, right?"

Catra and Adora looked at each other with their mouths open.

"Right?" Scorpia said, looking confused. "I read the queen's statement about it—lots of people did, I mean, it was big news for She-Ra to be gone. You went into the portal to close it, the queen said, and the portal goes between dimensions. I did listen to *some* stuff Entrapta said."

"That would actually explain a lot," Adora said.

"Scorpia," said Catra, her heartrate picking up, "never let anyone tell you you're dumb again."

Scorpia frowned. "Who's been saying I'm dumb?"

"The portal needed the runestone from She-Ra's Sword to open," Adora said excitedly. "So maybe the other runestones are, I don't know, maybe they could also be used to open portals between dimensions—"

"—and that's why you feel closer to real here," Catra finished. "You're closer to this dimension. Maybe the runestone really *is* a

door you could just step through, you just can't open it by yourself!"

"I didn't follow all of that," said Scorpia, who couldn't hear Adora, "but it sounds like that's why you need me to connect to the runestone? To let her out?"

"Yes!" Catra swallowed and stepped back. "Try it. Try it, Scorpia."

Scorpia took a deep breath, rolled her shoulders, cracked her neck. "Okay. Here goes."

She strode confidently up to the Garnet, just to one side of Adora, and laid the tip of one pincer against it.

Nothing happened.

Scorpia furrowed her brow, concentrating. After a minute she closed her eyes and took a few more deep breaths, pressing both pincers hard against the runestone's surface.

"I think I've almost got it," she said. "No, nope, definitely not. Maybe if I—no. Come on, Scorpia, you can totally… do this…" She blew out a gusty sigh, opening her eyes. "I totally can't do this. I just don't even know how to start! I don't know how it's supposed to feel!" She looked at Adora. "Don't worry, I'm not giving up! I'm going to go… do some research, yeah! See if I can find some of the old family records about the Garnet. Maybe that'll help."

"Okay," Adora said uncertainly.

Scorpia turned to go, and tugged a frowning Catra out the door with her.

"I think we gotta talk about this, wildcat," Scorpia said, once the door was closed between them and Adora.

"What do you mean?"

"Look, don't take this the wrong way—I know Adora is like, a whole *thing* for you, I know it's complicated. But are you really, really sure you want to let her out?" Scorpia winced. "I mean, as soon as you do, won't she go straight back to the Rebellion and start kicking our butts again?"

Catra blinked at her, stunned.

She was right. Of course she was right. If they did manage to free Adora, she would leave. It might take her a few days, but she would leave. Again.

"What are you saying, that we should leave her like that forever?" Catra growled.

"Maybe not forever, but—well, it's not that different than keeping her prisoner, is it? Which is definitely what we would have done if we'd ever captured She-Ra," Scorpia said. "Heck, it's probably nicer than keeping her prisoner. No one can hurt her where she is, not even us. I just… whatever your Big Plan is, I know it's close. And having She-Ra around would screw it up, right?"

The invasion of Salineas was supposed to launch in three days. If Adora caught the slightest hint of what was happening, she'd be in a perfect position to interfere. And then she'd leave.

Or Catra could tell Adora that Scorpia couldn't activate the runestone, and there wasn't any way to free her. It might very well be true. Adora would believe her, and she'd stay. Catra would have her at her side forever. What would it even feel like, to win *and* keep Adora? The idea was hypnotizing.

"Go look for those records," Catra said, belatedly remembering Scorpia's presence. "It would be useful for you to have access to your runestone's power, regardless of what we decide to do with it, right?"

"Sure," Scorpia said, looking concerned. "Then we can talk about this some more, if you want?"

"Yeah, whatever."

She watched Scorpia disappear around a corner, then stepped back into the Black Garnet Chamber. Right now she could stall with the truth, tell Adora that Scorpia would keep trying—

Adora was gone.

Catra called for her a couple times, without the faintest whisper of a reply. With a long, unsteady breath, Catra slid down the side of the Garnet to sit with her back against it. Adora had been too tired to stay, too tired to answer, even here where it was easier. Who knew when she would be able to come back. Catra might already have seen her for the last time.

*No, I don't get to win and keep Adora*. Catra pulled her knees up to her chest and buried her face in them. *She's losing this fight. If I let her stay like this, I really will be killing her—or worse*.

But maybe just a few more days, until after Salineas? Catra was so close to the victory she needed, the proof of her worth that she'd been chasing and chasing for so long, and never found.

She shifted her foot, and paper crinkled. Adora's letter was still where she'd dropped it, when she ran forward to press her hands against the Garnet. Reluctantly, as if someone were forcing her to, she picked it up and read it again. Read about how much Adora missed her. How much she wanted them to be together again. *Love, Adora*.

*She loves me,* Catra thought desperately*. Maybe she won't leave me*. But she knew better. It wouldn't matter how much it hurt her to leave Catra, wouldn't matter how Catra argued or begged. Adora would keep fighting for what she thought was right, a drive that Catra would never really understand. *She'll leave me.*

Catra could only think of one way to keep that from happening.

By the time Adora had enough awareness to recognize the voice, it had grown frantic.

"Adora! Adora! Come on, just this one last time, *answer*. You promised you would answer! *Adora!*"

Catra. Adora's mind flooded with feelings and memories. Catra, her sharp smile and glittering eyes. Her gorgeous raspy voice and the way it made Adora feel strange in the pit of her stomach. Catra curled up at the foot of her bed. Catra slicing her claws down Adora's back. Catra reading her letter, and saying *I've been in love with you since before I knew how to tie my shoes*.

"Adora?"

Adora, that was *her* name. Adora struggled, stacking moments of focus on top of each other, slowly remembering—growing up in the Horde, with *Catra,* finding a sword in the Whispering Woods, Glimmer, She-Ra, she was *Adora*—

"That's right! Keep going! A little further!"

Adora opened her eyes.

She was looking through dark red glass—the Black Garnet—and there was Catra, her hands pressed against it. Scorpia stood behind her, looking nervous and shaken.

"Catra," Adora said, and Catra sagged with relief. "How long has it been?"

"Only a day," Catra said. "Scorpia's ready to try again."

"I didn't find a lot in the way of records," Scorpia said, "but there was some stuff about confidence being key. So." She straightened her shoulders. "Givin' it all the confidence I've got! Maybe I can activate the Garnet just long enough to let you through into this dimension. It would only take a second."

"Wait," Adora said, suddenly nervous. "If I *am* dead after all…" She raised her hands to match Catra's, pressed against the Garnet. While she couldn't actually touch the surface of the runestone, she could definitely feel that she was reaching a boundary of some sort, pressing up against some whisper-thin barrier between her and reality. She swallowed. "'Releasing' me might do the opposite of what we want. It might… send me on, or whatever. Release me in the wrong direction."

Color drained from Catra's face. "I hadn't thought of that."

"So, you don't want us to try it?" Scorpia asked. "Wouldn't blame you. We can do more research, make sure—"

"No, that's not what I mean," Adora said. "I don't think we can wait. I… I don't know if I'll be able…"

"You might not come back," Catra said. "The next time you fade out." Her voice got tighter. "We have to try now."

Adora nodded. "Before you do, just in case, I just—I just wanted to tell you." Her eyes flicked to Scorpia, wishing she wasn't here for this. "Just wanted to say it again. That I love you." The words made her smile, in spite of everything, made her so light with joy she could barely stand it. Smiling crookedly, she added, "And I'm glad I got to haunt you, for a while."

Catra looked like someone had kicked her in the stomach. She turned away *almost* before Adora could see the tears in her eyes, and said "Do it."

Scorpia took a deep breath, and stepped up to touch the Garnet—embrace it, almost, one pincer on either side of the narrow base. She dropped her forehead against the surface of the stone—

A spark, a flare of red that lit the Garnet and the whole room like a flash of lightning.

Adora fell through the surface of the runestone as if it were an open window, and landed in a heap on the floor.

"Adora!" Catra cried, though Adora could barely hear her. Her ears were ringing, her stomach turning. Her mouth tasted like metal, and her eyes wouldn't focus.

"Adora? *Adora?* Say something!" Catra's hands on her, pulling her into her lap, checking for injuries.

"Ow," Adora said thickly, and then wheezed as Catra crushed her against her chest.

"You're alive," Catra said. "You're alive, you're alive, are you okay? How do you feel?" Over her shoulder, Adora could see Scorpia glancing between them and the Garnet, which had gone dark again. Scorpia tapped it thoughtfully, but without any response.

"I feel weird," Adora said, "but… okay? I think?" Her lungs were remembering how to breathe now, her heart remembering how to beat. She was able to tighten her arms around Catra, and marvel at the total effortlessness of *existing*. She could feel Catra, warm and solid in her arms. She could feel metal plating underneath her, smell stale Fright Zone air—she'd entirely *forgotten* smell—oh, she could smell Catra, too, all up around her, heartbreakingly familiar and spicy-sweet.

Catra started laughing, and then they were both laughing, and crying, and pulling back barely far enough to see each other. Catra cradled Adora's face in her hands. "You're alive," she said, and kissed her.

Adora had a moment of flatlining shock, and at the stiff lack of response Catra began to draw back—which was the last thing in the world Adora wanted. She lunged into the kiss, pulling Catra closer with an arm around her shoulders and a hand tangling in her hair—too much, too fast. It took a few moments to find an equilibrium, but they found it, slow and soft and aching. Adora didn't want to ever stop, but eventually Catra pulled away to breathe, and Adora remembered that was a thing she needed to do, too.

"I'm alive," she said, between gulps of air, and laughed a little hysterically. "I can't wait to see Bow and Glimmer and Swift Wind, I can't wait to see their faces, I can't…" Her stomach went suddenly cold, her smile draining away. She hadn't even thought about what would happen if she actually did get brought back. "Oh no," she whispered.

"You're gonna leave," Catra said, her face extremely neutral. "You have to. Don't you."

"I can't… I can't leave you again, but I can't stay here, even if I wanted to I *can't*…"

Catra got up, pulling Adora to her feet, and steadying her when she wobbled. "I know," she said, and picked up a bag from the floor, hefting it onto her shoulder. "That's why I'm going with you."

Adora stared, mouth dropping open.

"Wh-where are you going exactly?" Scorpia squeaked. Gosh, Adora had completely forgotten Scorpia was there.

"Bright Moon or whatever." Catra shrugged, looking determinedly casual.

"But—but Hordak," Scorpia said, "the war, the big plan—"

"Screw them," Catra said, a little heat entering her voice. "What did Hordak and the war ever do for me? Except beat me down as much as they could, and keep me chasing something I was never going to catch. I'm done."

Adora could barely breathe through disbelief and joy. She wrapped her arms around Catra and let out something between a laugh and a sob.

"So you're just… changing sides?" Scorpia sounded borderline hysterical. "You're joining the *princesses*?"

"Yeah, pretty much," Catra said with a disgusted sigh, holding Adora just as tightly. "Here's hoping I'm not allergic to glitter. Might not be all bad, you know. I figure there's a non-zero chance the princesses will help me rescue Entrapta from Beast Island, if she's still alive." Adora nodded eagerly. Catra pulled back from her, gripping her hand instead, and looked a gaping Scorpia up and down. "You wanna come with us?"

Scorpia hesitated a long moment. Adora wondered uneasily if they were going to have to fight their way out. She'd rather not hurt Scorpia, after she just helped free her from whatever between-dimension she'd been trapped in…

"Can I bring Emily?" Scorpia said at last.

Catra rolled her eyes, even as her whole stance softened with relief. "Sure, why not."

Adora and Catra ended up waiting in one corner of Scorpia's rooms while she packed her things—a battered stuffed animal, a framed picture, other odds and ends. Scorpia had more *stuff* than most Horde soldiers, but at least her packing gave Adora more time to adjust to being real again. She'd stumbled a lot, during the nerve-wracking walk through Horde hallways to Scorpia's quarters.

"Everything feels amazing," Adora murmured, running a hand over the pipes and panels on the wall. "Everything smells amazing. Even sights and sounds are sharper, and I didn't think they had been any different."

"Can't you think of anything better to touch than the wall?" Catra said, in a low voice that made Adora's face heat up.

Adora smiled and eagerly—if shyly—ran her palms down Catra's arms instead. Purring very quietly, Catra grabbed one hand and pushed her face against it, scent-marking.

"Yeah, this is better," Adora said, smiling so wide it hurt. "I—Catra, I can't believe this is happening. I'm afraid I'm going to wake up and none of it's real. I'm alive, and you love me, and we're leaving here together… Are you *sure* about that?"

Catra's voice was light. "What, you don't want me to come?"

"I don't want you to regret coming."

Catra's expression went more serious, looking at Adora steadily. "Of all the things I have to regret, the one that ends with me getting to kiss you whenever I want? *Probably* not gonna make the list."

Adora let out a shaky breath. "Whenever you want, huh?"

"Whenever *you* want, I guess, since otherwise we'd never stop."

"Why would we want to stop?"

They came together again like an inevitability, and though the kiss was still gentle and searching, Adora could feel a heat building behind it that she wanted more of, wanted a chance to explore. With Catra. Always and only with Catra.

Scorpia cleared her throat, startling them apart.

"I'm ready," Scorpia said. "Just gotta track down Emily."

"We can't go dragging Adora hither and yon through the Fright Zone, someone's bound to recognize her," Catra said.

"Oh, yeah, I already thought of that!" Scorpia threw open the door to her closet, revealing a suit of ground-soldier armor, complete with helmet. "It's not gonna fit her very well, but at least no one can see her face."

Adora reluctantly let go of Catra and starting pulling on the armor. She could have put Catra and probably Kyle in there with her, but thankfully the helmet was a standard size.

Scorpia, giving Adora furtive glances, pulled Catra aside. "Not trying to tell you your business, wildcat," she said in what she clearly thought was a quiet voice. "I just… thought we kinda had something, you know? Are you sure about… her? I mean, this is all really sudden."

"This is the furthest thing from sudden, Scorpia," Catra said, smiling almost dreamily. "This has been coming since we were kids. I just didn't think there was any chance, anymore, after… you know."

Adora, trying not to obviously watch, caught a sideways glimpse of Scorpia's pained expression, and heard Catra sigh.

"Listen, I know I haven't always treated you right," Catra said awkwardly, "and I can't pretend I didn't know… what you wanted from me."

Adora gave up trying not to watch.

"But I didn't tell you any lies, and I didn't make you any promises."

"No, I know," Scorpia said, her tone striving valiantly for stoicism, "and hey, as long as we can be friends…"

"Of course we can." Catra laid a hand against the hard shell of Scorpia's pincer. "I'm really glad you're coming with us. I really hoped you would."

Scorpia brightened at that, her face softening, and Adora stopped being quite so unwilling to ever turn her back on her. She pulled the helmet down over her face.

"I'm ready," she called.

Catra broke into a smile, grabbing Adora's hand. "Let's go. I can't wait to get out of here."

Baffled guards put them in a meeting room, when they reached Bright Moon Palace, and sent someone to fetch the Queen. Adora fidgeted while the guards stared and whispered behind their hands.

Queen Angella's voice drifted down the hallway toward them. "What do you mean, Horde defectors? You're awfully white around the eyes over some soldiers seeking asylum, Juliet."

"We're going to let them stay, right?" Glimmer's voice, and Adora nearly combusted with anticipation. "They don't want to be part of the Horde—they're like Adora, Mom—"

"It's more complicated than that, Your Majesty. Just… just look for yourself."

And there they were in the doorway, Angella and Glimmer and Bow, too, standing and staring. Fighting sudden tears, Adora watched their gazes flick around the room—gigantic Scorpia and her alarming Horde bot, Adora's old team ranged nervously behind her (they'd run into them on their way out), and then Catra—*Catra!*—clinging tightly to her hand—

"Adora?" Bow said, choked and disbelieving.

"It's me," she said, and barely finished the words before Glimmer screamed and tackled her.

There was a lot of crying, after that, and bewildered questions, and not waiting for answers, and Swift Wind bursting through the window shouting "I KNEW IT!" while showering them all with glass.

Hours later, Adora was on a pile of cushions in her old room, with Catra flattened against her side, clutching her hand and only just beginning to believe no one was going to shoot her or throw her in a cell. Snacks were scattered everywhere, Bow was leaning on

her other side, and Swift Wind was asleep on the bed, snoring mightily.

"Your other friends are settled in the guest room." Glimmer closed the door behind the guard who had brought the update, and ran to flop across Adora's lap. "And Flutter-whatever-their-name-really-is said they're gonna leave town for a bit while things get settled. Which Mom wasn't thrilled about but they're already gone. They said something about not being surprised, after what they read in that letter?"

Catra gritted her teeth about the letter bit, but didn't respond to it. Instead, she said dryly, "Hard to believe the queen's any less thrilled about Double Trouble than about me."

"Are you kidding? Mom's *giddy* about you. What kind of war survives the defection of one side's head strategist? You're Mom's new *favorite*."

"Huh," Catra said. "Never been anybody's favorite before."

"Not true," said Adora, squeezing her hand. "You were always my favorite."

"And you're our friend now, Catra," Bow said casually, eyeing those clasped hands. "You're gonna have more emotional support than you know what to do with."

"Spare me," Catra muttered, face turning red.

Glimmer giggled sleepily. "I still don't understand exactly how either of you are here. But I'm not questioning it. For the first time in a *long* time, it feels like things might turn out all right."

"Yeah," Adora said, bumping her forehead against Catra's.

"Yeah," Catra said softly. "They might."

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AFTER-CREDITS SCENE:

In another universe, after the war, Catra steps inside Bright Moon Palace for the first time. The ragged band with her is dirty, exhausted, traumatized, but happy to be home.

Catra looks around in bemusement at all the pastels, marble and gold… then stops dead.

Adora, jerked to a stop by their clasped hands, turns back. "Catra? What is it?"

Staring ahead at what seems, to everyone else, to be empty air, Catra says hesitantly, "Queen Angella?"

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